



Rarely has a citizen's movement of such magnitude and commonality of purpose been witnessed in India. It was a transformational moment for Indian society.

India's dictionary of life. Now, it is back and tomorrow will never be the same.

The vulnerability from the economic slide is still to play itself out with the reality of layoffs and pay cuts measured against the

booster shots and words of reassurance from the Government. Yet, it has the potential to do enormous psychological damage to the collective psyche. Millions of Indians had mortgaged their lifestyle and their future; from cars to houses, luxuries like plasma TVs, flash clothes, music systems and kids' education to home improvement, was all bought on credit cards or bank loans. The threat of losing jobs, or actually losing one, when everything you own is still not paid for, could cause incalculable social upheavals and trauma. Already, the downsizing and downgrading of lifestyles and social habits like eating out, frequent holidays abroad, shopping binges and entertaining is causing mental stress and strains as people struggle to adjust. The axis of life has shifted and finding a new balance will be a painful, even de-

meaning, process.

The other vulnerability was no less painful and psychologically damaging: the growing terror threat. India's 26/11 was a journey into the heart of darkness but also a shocking exposé of India's security apparatus, its politicians and bureaucrats and the systemic failures right down the line. The loss of life was matched by the loss of faith in the state's ability to protect its citizens and its sovereignty.

Yet, so cataclysmic was the event that it has brought an unprecedented and positive response. At one level were the official efforts to rectify the serious flaws exposed by the Mumbai carnage. At another equally important level was the sense of collective anger, unity and resolve evident in the countrywide candlelight vigils and marches and the expressions of hope and courage and convergence of purpose and action. Over 50,000 people gathered on the streets of Mumbai to express solidarity and push for urgent reform. Rarely, if ever, has a citizen's movement of such magnitude and commonality been witnessed in India. No less heartening was the fact that Muslims in large numbers sent out their own message of solidarity and communal concord by marching through the streets wearing black bands in memory of the tragedy and those who lost their lives. That alone was a fitting enough riposte to the tradesmen of terror but if the public campaign is sustained and brings genuine change, and extends to areas of common concern, it will be a transformational moment for Indian society. ■

HIGHS & LOWS

● Adiga wins Booker Prize.

Right To Information improves openness in local government.

Smoking ban in public places and offices comes into force.

Large-scale discounts on everything from cars to clothes.

Society unites and patriotism is in after Mumbai attacks.

● Economic crisis, terror inspires a mood of gloom and doom.

Kidney racket exposes rich exploiting the poor.

Aarushi murder shows police and media in poor light.

Malls, hotels, eateries and entertainment suffer badly.

Private celebrations downsized.